CYBERCHONDRIA NEW AGE MALAISE

AI symptom checkers and online health content are fuelling a surge in self-diagnosis, driving panic, delaying treatment and a rise in self-medication

By **SONALI ACHARJEE**
Illustrations by **NILANJAN DAS**

Seven months ago, 41-year-old Ritoban Sen, an Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad graduate working with a leading bank in Mumbai, noticed a small lump on his knee. With rising paranoia, spurred by a family history of cancer, he fed every detail into ChatGPT, and received an elaborate explanation suggesting bone cancer. He consulted three oncologists in Mumbai, all of whom diagnosed simple inflammation and ruled out a biopsy. Still unconvinced, Sen flew to New York City for a fourth opinion, with the same result. "I feel foolish now, but the anxiety then was overwhelming," Sen says with a laugh. If the hypochondriac of yore imagined the slightest bodily symptom as evidence of some debilitating disease, now he has a tool to confirm his worst fears: Dr ChatGPT. Together, they have spawned a creature called the cyberchondriac, whose quick search for online symptoms rapidly spirals into repeated, obsessive checking, with each result escalating anxiety rather than resolving it.